



△ Detail showing tinted diamonds in varicoloured gold setting

Frederick the Great's snuffbox

Frederick II “the Great” of Prussia (r.1740–86) loved snuffboxes, and his collection supposedly included one for each day of the year. He was also known for his liking of the green gemstone chrysoprase, and he commissioned eight snuffboxes made from the mineral. London-trained designer Jean Guillaume George Kruger is thought to have made this example in around 1765, and Frederick later presented it to his brother Augustus Wilhelm, Prince of Prussia, as a gift.

The oval box and its cover are both made from single pieces of chrysoprase, a green variety of chalcedony (see pp.146–49). Diamonds and other gems are mounted on varicoloured gold in the forms of scrolls, vines, and sprays of flowers; and pale pink, green, and lemon-yellow foil has been placed behind the diamonds to tint them subtly. The

interior of the lid is bordered by gold and engraved with more flowers and scrolls.

Frederick was renowned for his military achievements, but also for his patronage of the arts. He was fond of fine materials, and among these he so favoured

chrysoprase that towards the end of his life he had pieces of chrysoprase set out for him to look at alongside his boxes and jewels. His interest in elegant boxes was influenced by his mother Sophia-Dorothea's collection, and he kept a snuffbox on his person at

all times. This proved fortuitous in 1759 at the Battle of Kunersdorf during the Seven Years' War, when he was hit by a Russian bullet – it was deflected by the snuffbox in his pocket, saving his life.



Jewelled mother-of-pearl snuffbox, commissioned by Frederick the Great



Frederick the Great of Prussia pictured at the Battle of Kunersdorf in 1759, where his snuffbox deflected a Russian bullet, and so saved his life

His approach to aesthetic quality... was robust

Tim **Blanning**

Author, on Frederick the Great

Key dates

1712–1786

